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Bruce Johnstone

Bruce Johnstone has distinguished himself as one of the top baritone saxophonists in the jazz world. He was a key player with the Maynard Ferguson Band, and has performed frequently in venues across the globe. Bruce is currently the Director of Curriculum Jazz at SUNY Fredonia.

Bruce was interviewed in Dunkirk, New York on October 11, 2013, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm in Fredonia, New York, actually we're in Dunkirk, but we're both here because of Fredonia sort of. And I'm happy to have Bruce Johnstone here, baritone sax extraordinaire and composer and arranger.

BJ: Thank you.

MR: It's been a long way from New Zealand.

BJ: It is.

MR: I saw a thing — we were just talking about a little YouTube thing, and apparently one of your students made a comment under it, and he said about Bruce, "he gets up every day at 5 a.m. and practices for three hours." I'd like to see you do that. I'd like to see you do that. Now, is that true?

BJ: No it's not. No it's not.

MR: Okay.

BJ: But I do practice a lot, but I think they're building a myth, which is fine if they want to do that. But obviously they must have some idle time that they need to be more deeply involved in.

MR: At this stage in your playing and your career, what do you find is interesting and useful to practice?

BJ: I practice things that are hard. I practice tunes that have different chord changes, things that don't lay correctly. And they don't lay naturally under my hands. And so I'll work them slowly. Back when I was learning "Giant Steps" I practiced it as a ballad. And gradually got where the most comfortable transitions were. And that seems to work for a lot of people. Don Menza had told me that he did the same thing. So I think we all do things in a similar way, just like that Oriental martial arts thing where people are doing everything slowly, and then if they get into a fight [scats] and these guys have got control over what they do, and they're down at a slow speed so they can then increase.

MR: Yeah, that's interesting because I think it's also probably very useful for playing the rests. Because rests are harder to play at slow tempos.

BJ: Yeah. They are. In fact there's a story about Vido Musso? He was on Benny Goodman's band. And he was having trouble playing a phrase. And Benny said to him, "are you having trouble with the notes?" And he said, "no, I'm having trouble with the rests." Which a lot of the kids I find have troubles with rests or even with long notes, even with a dotted half note, it can turn into seven beats. Or for two — and then they'll just blindly jump ahead. So you have to rein people in and say you have to count. You have to be aware of where you are.

MR: Um hum. It's funny because I'll tell them to do this and that with rests, and then I'll play in a thing like we're doing this weekend and I'll find that I make the same — like I should be listening to myself and not jumping in too soon, etcetera.

BJ: Uh huh. It happens to me too.

MR: Yeah. I've been thinking recently, we're a similar age, and I think about the term "making it" in the music business. Because when we were younger and we wanted to "make it" in the music business, and what that might have meant. Do you remember what that meant for you when you were like a teenager?

BJ: Well it meant being accepted by people who were older than you. When I was 16 I was in the New Zealand Radio Orchestra, which meant I was a government employee at 16. So I would get done with school, take a bus in and be in the studio with all these guys who were far older than I was. But at that stage I had essentially made it, because I was treated not as a kid, but I was treated as an equal. And that's really important. And the other thing that, when people say "making it," when I look back to the Maynard Ferguson albums that I was on, at the time it was just another day at the office. And it wasn't until several years later when I listened back to that stuff that you realize how special it was, and what an impression you had made. And these days I'm getting contacts from people who are a lot younger who have discovered these Maynard Ferguson and Woody Herman jams that I was involved with, and they're contacting me and asking me about reeds, mouthpieces, what was I thinking at the time, what was my concept, how come I didn't sound like a baritone player when I played. And so they're getting in-depth with me.

MR: Did you have — I don't know how to ask this — did you have a concept, like they think you might have?

BJ: I think I probably did. I listened to a lot of baritone players when I was a kid, on recordings. And for a large part they sounded clunky and clumsy and certain parts of the instrument were strong and certain parts were weak. And I was listening primarily to tenor players and alto players, people like Lester Young, who had shaped his sound on a C melody saxophone sound that Frankie Trumbauer had. So his sound was lighter. And then Stan Getz, who had listened to alto players when he first played, early on, when he

control over the top end of his instrument. And that's something that I wanted to do. And because I also — I liked Cannonball Adderley. I wanted to bring that same concept. I figured the guy's got the same amount of fingers and the same amount of keys, why can't I do that on the baritone? And so a lot of what I did is in the upper register and going into harmonics. I want it to be as clean as the rest of the sound of the instrument. So you have a pyramid effect. The top end of the horn is like this and the bottom is wide. So you get a slightly more edgy sound on the top and a nice broad bottom, and the middle range is still clear. And so a lot of people thought that I was playing a tenor when I first came to the stage.

MR: Did you ever consider playing the tenor?

BJ: I tried. I get a lousy sound out of a tenor. I basically have an E flat head I think. I'm more comfortable playing baritone and alto, although I haven't played alto to the extent that I have played baritone. But I do enjoy it when I do. I play soprano as well.

MR: I like that, an E flat head. It's interesting because there are some tunes that just lay so well on an E flat instrument, depending on what key they were written in. Like "Misty" is just like perfect.

BJ: Right in the middle. With the string group that I'm playing for I've moved a couple of keys so that I'm playing more at the top end of the horn. For example, "East of the Sun" is usually done in F. I do it in C. Because when I do like a solo intro, and I'm right up at the top of the horn in the kind of mid to upper tenor range, which has all the clarity in the world. And then I've got all the rest of the horn to play with.

MR: Where did you get the music in New Zealand. Do they have decent record stores and so forth? Was your family musical?

BJ: My family was musical. In fact they told me that two weeks before I was born they got front row seats to a concert by Artie Shaw. And so they used to take me all kinds of places before I was born, so I was absorbing Artie Shaw at the time. And so they had a huge record collection. There was Artie Shaw and Woody — in fact my parents were just blown away when I got the job with Woody.

MR: Oh that's cool.

BJ: And so I was listening to Charlie Parker and Coleman Hawkins, Lester, and Basie and everybody, when I was just a little kid. Because there was no T.V. at the time when I was growing up, and so on rainy days before I went to kindergarten, my parents would just sit me in front of the — well my mother would sit me in front of the record player and just let me go. And I was listening to a lot of Dixieland as well, some Louis Armstrong, Jack Teagarden, and Miff Mole and his Little Molars. Remember them? So it was a really great musical upbringing. My parents were both guitar players and banjo players. And

stuff being played. But record stores — to a degree, to a degree. Probably a better selection of jazz record stores than we have now in the States, but I used to buy directly from the States. I had a subscription to "DownBeat" magazine and I'd read all these things, and I'd also get "Voice of America" on shortwave radio. And so I would hear all these great things like Art Blakey, Horace Silver, Max Roach, all these wonderful players. And the guy would say, "and this is from their latest album," bang. So I would write off a letter to my contacts in San Francisco and I'd get a little package back. So that was nice.

MR: A lot of people have mentioned "Voice of America" in Japan and Europe of course. That was really great.

BJ: And I did get to meet Willis Conover one time. He was the voice of "Voice of America" jazz. And I met him in Warsaw, in Poland, when we were with Woody.

MR: Was there a role model for you about a musician who felt that, okay, I have to leave New Zealand, I have to take these stepping stones to get where I want to get.

BJ: I think it was a logical progression. I was always setting myself up against people, and ranking myself. Where do I fit within the scene? And after I'd pretty much played with everybody that I admired and I realized I was being accepted by these folks, then I would run into players from other countries who would come in, and a bunch of guys from Australia had said, "you should come to Sydney," you know, "things will really happen for you." So after hearing this enough times, when I was 21 I said okay. So I had a thousand dollars and a return airfare, and went to Sydney. And when I was down to my last hundred and fifty bucks and all of a sudden I walked onto a gig which, strange enough it was a Dixieland job, and so I was playing clarinet and baritone and alto with this very strange band. It was called the Ray Price Quartet. Ray Price was a banjo player. There was no drums and no bass. The piano player was playing bass lines on keyboard. Ray became the percussion section, and we had a trumpet player, his name was King Fisher — he was an American kid and his father was Freddie Schnickelfritz Fisher, who, there's a YouTube video of him playing "Turkey in the Straw" which is absolutely hilarious. And this guy was kind of a Denver version of Spike Jones. So King had all this Dixieland stuff in his head. And they had a repertoire of stuff that they were doing, which was Dixieland, swing, and even stuff in odd time signatures. We used to do "America" in 7/4. You know [scats rhythm]. And he would take great delight in having the audiences clap in seven. And everyone would say wow, clapping in seven.

MR: Like "Unsquare Dance."

BJ: Yeah. Exactly. Yup. But that was a funny gig. And that was a six night a week job. And he was a kind of a national figure in Australia. So we recorded several albums with him.

And we did tours of Northern Australia and the Outback. And it was great. So we got to see the country up on the Great Barrier Reef.

MR: You were making it.

BJ: Making it, yeah. Pretty much. And plus I was playing bebop on Sundays.

MR: Oh, nice. Do you remember what you were making, what your salary would have been at the time?

BJ: Oh, I think it was maybe about $60 a week, which at the time was pretty good. It was more than a lot of people were making, and I had a car and I had a nice apartment.

MR: And doing what you want.

BJ: Busy, yeah. And from there it kind of transformed into studio work. And the last years I was in Australia I was assistant musical director of a big nightclub called Chequers, which used to have name American acts come through. And I was staff on four T.V. shows. So that was a regular four days a week I was doing that, plus I was doing recording sessions for back-up rock things. It was pretty much a seven day a week, 18-hour day existence. And it was great. The money was terrific. But in making it with that much intensity meant that you were just completely wiped out all the time. You didn't have time to really develop anything new. So one night I went home and I said to my wife, "can we go to Europe?" And she said, "yeah, let's go to Europe." So we woke up the next morning and she said "did you say we're going to Europe?" And I said, "yeah, let's go." So we looked at the shipping schedule and there was a ship leaving a week from then. So we got our passports, went down, sold a bunch of instruments, and got on the ship and went to Europe.

MR: What would you have sold? Stuff that you said I don't need this?

BJ: Right. I had two soprano saxophones that I sold. They were a hundred numbers apart. They were both Selmers, and I kick myself for dropping these things. One sounded like an English horn and the other one had a much bigger, more of a jazz soprano sound. So whenever people used to hire me I'd ask them what kind of sound they wanted and bring the appropriate instrument. I sold a really good clarinet. I sold a really good alto flute, a really good bass flute, and I kick myself all over the place for letting go of — but there is just so much plumbing you can carry when you're changing countries. But England was okay. It was an entirely different scene. There was nothing much established. And the contacts that I had over there had known me as a studio player, and they weren't. So when people were offering me jobs they'd say oh no, no, he's a studio player. He's not a jazz player. So I had to, just a minute, I had to do that. And there was also another odd faction in England. I was playing something for John Surman on a South African group called the Brotherhood of Breath. Very avante garde, you know, very violent kind of

music, but they were good players. Alan Skidmore was playing tenor on it. A wonderful alto player, an African alto player, named Dudu Pukwana.

MR: Dudu Pukwana.

BJ: He's kind of like an African version of Ornette Coleman. Fabulous player. And so they were going to do the Berlin Jazz Festival. But they hadn't mentioned anything to me about it. And I said, "so am I going to Berlin with you?" And they said, "no." And I said, "oh, why?" They said, "oh because you sound too much like an American." And I said, coming from New Zealand, "isn't that the object?" They wanted somebody who didn't have that American sound I guess I had.

MR: Which means what?

BJ: I have no idea. I just didn't go to Berlin with them. You know I didn't play with them anymore. But I played with some of the newer avante garde, new age rocker kind of guys like Bryan Ferry. And I was holding down a six night a week gig in Nottingham of all places. I would have to drive from London and stay over a couple of nights and play and have just a big dance band. But we would just do all kinds of stuff.

MR: And this was what years?

BJ: Probably '69, '70. And I just got sick of that and one day I turned to my wife and said "I think it's time we got out of here." So we moved, burned a few bridges, and went to France.

MR: Were you hearing Coltrane and the sort of avante garde, well sort of progressive stuff that was going on in the sixties? Were you hearing it and listening to it?

BJ: I was listening to it. I admired Coltrane. I thought it was absolutely fantastic. But I didn't want to copy him because it was so unique and I didn't want to make a pale image of what Coltrane was doing. A lot of what he was doing was beyond my understanding at that point. And I had needed to just sit down and listen to him. I was also familiar with Albert Ayler, who was just ripping and tearing. But I was more back in the tradition. I was kind of steeped in the Lester Young style of playing. And one of my favorite tenor players was Dexter Gordon, who was just terrific. I mean I had a ton of his albums. And I used to like the kind of sarcastic way that he played [scats]. He would do that. And you would hear these little phrases on all of his recordings. But he could interpret a ballad like nobody's business. And so after being in France and then kind of working my way up through Europe, I wound up in Copenhagen and guess who's on the schedule for Montmartre? Dexter. And also I scout around and Webster was also playing there at the time, Sahib Shihab was playing there, Kenny Drew was playing there, and there were so many wonderful bass players there. Neils Henning was there, a great player by the name of Bo Stief, who is still there and we still communicate, and a guy by the name of Mads

played with Bill Evans, recorded with Dexter, and he's still one of the best drummers I've ever heard. So I kind of stumbled into this scene by having the nerve to go up and ask Dexter if I'd get to sit in with him.

MR: Did he like, put you through your paces sort of?

BJ: Oh yeah. Yeah.

MR: And tell me about that again.

BJ: Well I asked him if I could sit in and he said, "well have you got any chops?"

MR: He said do you have any chops?

BJ: Yeah. Meaning can I get around the horn. And I said well there are some days I do, some days I don't. And he was pretty bleary. He'd been drinking pretty hard. So he said, you know, "Stella By Starlight." And I said, "yeah." And he said, "in A?" Which puts me in F sharp. And I wasn't about to let this go, so I said, "sure." And so we went on stage and Dexter started out "Stella by Starlight" and playing a long, long chorus. I mean, many choruses. He quit in the middle of a chorus and went [motions]. You son of a bitch.

MR: This was definitely on purpose.

BJ: Oh yeah.

MR: Especially to stop in the middle of a chorus.

BJ: Absolutely. He wanted to know if I knew where I was.

MR: "Stella" is in B flat.

BJ: Usually it's in B flat, so it was kind of a half step. And so he played a brilliant rhythm solo. But I was also doing the ugly fan thing — I was standing on stage saying wow, this is Dexter Gordon. I have all his records. But the rhythm section was great. It was Neils Henning was playing bass, and Kenny Drew was playing piano. And they knew what Dexter was doing. And Kenny Drew just kind of rolled his eyes. And he walked me through it. The chord changes — every change was like riding on rails [claps]. There was no surprises, everything was just nice, nice, nice, and it was a delight. An absolute delight. Then Dexter caught me the next day, and I don't know how he found my phone number because I was staying in a house that a Danish woman was — she would rent rooms. And so he was very nice and he said, "can you cover for me? I have a gig in Aarhus that I have to back out of. Can you do it?" And I said, "sure, I'd love to." And he said, "good, 'cause I told them you could."

MR: I'm sorry, I can just hear his voice too, his slow way of talking, down here. Oh that's great.

BJ: And so after that we were friends. We played a lot together. And he didn't realize that I was picking his brains and getting a lot of his stylistic things and putting them on my instrument, things that he and Ben would do. They would learn the lyrics to everything.

the mists of time, everyone just plays the chorus. Dexter could stand up, in fact he wouldn't announce tunes lots of times, he would just get up and say, "a country dance was being held in a garden," and he'd recite the entire lyric of "Polka Dots and Moonbeams," and then just [scats].

MR: Oh, wow.

BJ: And it was magical because he would engage the audience to understand the story he was telling, and then play it. And you could feel it the whole way. And the sound, just the clarity of sound. Everything was solid from the bottom of the horn to the top of the horn. There were no — nothing sounded strained, and which was something I'd always heard with baritone players, the top end was always, you know, you're dragging it up with your lip. And so I watched him a lot as he was doing it, and he was really, really relaxed. And so I thought well I'll just put the Dexter Gordon thing in my head. And when I played the clarity came. And so that was some really, really valuable stuff that I was getting from those guys. And Ben Webster was also another one who, because he wouldn't fly, the Copenhagen Radio Orchestra would send me out with him so we'd ride trains and buses and boats and things to get to the gigs. And he would just sit around and talk to me. And he'd tell me about how Lester Young's mother used to make them sandwiches before he and Lester went down swimming. You know, just real stuff. And I thought he was just a charming guy. He also made the best coffee in Copenhagen.

MR: No kidding.

BJ: He told me, "hey, you want to come over for coffee?" I'd zoom over and we'd sit and chat and play a little.

MR: You can't buy that kind of stuff.

BJ: I know, I know. And I just feel really, really fortunate that I was able to stumble into this. Because of their influence in Copenhagen, players there moved up to their level. And when you hear somebody who can really play, you want to come up to their level and so I was doing that, the bass players and drummers and pianists all were trying to do that. And the legacy of what those guys left after they passed is still really solid in Denmark.

MR: Was there any racial issues at the time, there?

BJ: Yes. I was threatened once on stage by a black guy who had some brass knuckles, and he came up screaming at me, "how dare you play my music?" And I think he was just there on vacation, but he'd had a little much to drink and all of a sudden he resented the fact that a white guy could play blues. And so the Danes kind of chilled him out. I think Dexter slowed the guy down too. But he was ready to take a swing at me because all of a sudden he thought that I was taking a cheap shot. But yes, there was some racial issues. Not in Denmark other than these guys who would come in. But yes, in the States there

MR: Does it go under the heading of reverse?

BJ: I guess so. I guess, yeah. It's just a very strange thing. I'd glad it's kind of blown over. But at that time there was still factions and when I'd moved to New York, after I left Maynard, I would get calls from a couple of black clubs in Harlem and they would send somebody from the club to meet me at Grand Central Station and this guy's job was to stick with me the whole time that I was there. He would drink with me, he'd hang out with me, he was very protective if anybody approached me, and then he would escort me back to Grand Central Station at the end of the gig. And it was a little unnerving.

MR: It was a bit like being your bodyguard.

BJ: Yeah. So that was unnerving. And also I had started a fusion group called New York Mary, along with Rick Petrone and Joe Corsello. And we had two albums for Arista. And they did rather well. They were both "Hit Pick of the Month" in "Billboard" and "Cash Box," and usually when they do that they say, you know, best track is — they listed all the tracks on both albums. So the second album Arista sent out in a plain cover, just as a promo. And it was getting airplay like crazy on all the black radio stations from Boston to Washington to Chicago. And then all of a sudden it got pulled. And it was because somebody showed up with the picture of five white guys on the front. And that was the feeling at the time.

MR: You mean they were playing it but they didn't know that you were an all white band.

BJ: Yeah. Isn't that unnerving?

MR: Yeah, that's a good one.

BJ: I'd always thought that music really had no color and no barriers, but it did. Nowadays it's so much easier.

MR: If you look at the blues scene especially, it seems to be mostly dominated by white players.

BJ: Yeah. And they wear hats.

MR: Yeah.

BJ: It's like obligatory to wear a hat. You can't play the blues without a hat.

MR: Do you have an idea of why black musicians don't pursue the blues? I mean it's not like it's a great way to make a living I suppose, but I think there's something beyond that.

BJ: Yeah, I think there's some major social issues, that the black musicians want to move beyond that image. I heard a great joke. Remember Robert Johnson, the legendary guitar player who went down to the crossroads at midnight and sold his soul to Satan?

MR: Um hum.

BJ: Well there was a dyslexic blues player who decided that he was going to do the same thing. So he went down to the crossroads at midnight and sold his soul to Santa.

BJ: Yeah. Courtesy of Garrison Keeler.

MR: I see. That does sound like him. Well so how did you land with Maynard Ferguson?

BJ: I was playing at a club called Montmartre in Copenhagen and this English trumpet player came in and asked if he could sit in. And it turned out he was Maynard's lead trumpet player. And he was on vacation in Copenhagen and he said, "you know Maynard's going to be looking for a baritone player soon because the baritone player doesn't want to tour anymore. So he said if you're interested I'll give Maynard your info. So this was in the day when people sent telegrams. So I got a telegram from Maynard saying Al Downey told me about you and send me a tape. So I sent a tape. And the first track on it was "My Funny Valentine," which happened to be Maynard's wife's favorite tune. So then I got another telegram saying can you be in London on such and such a date and we'll be going to the States in three weeks. So I said okay. You know, a door opens, do you want to zoom through it. And I also got my first mention in "DownBeat" when I was in Copenhagen, because they used to have international rankings in, like a big column, and they mentioned that I was playing at the Montmartre, which was my own, kind of bizarre thing in Copenhagen. My first newspaper interview, I picked up the paper, this guy had come to interview me and I picked up a copy of the paper, it's all in Danish, and it's got a picture of me, and in the next column is a picture of Lee Morgan. And the headline was "*Lee Morgan skudt i New York*." *Skudt* means shot. So I appeared on the same day that they discovered that Lee Morgan got shot on the bandstand by his wife.

MR: God. Do you still have that?

BJ: No I don't. It's probably somewhere in my archive either in New Zealand or somewhere.

MR: Gee, timing. In retrospect, like when a gig like that happens and you meet somebody and then you get the call, do you quibble about money?

BJ: No. No. My parents had always said to me, because there was a huge recession in New Zealand when gasoline was rationed and all this kind of stuff. And a lot of people were unemployed. And when I was of employable age, my parents said, "if you get a job, be thankful you've got the job and work out the money later." And so Maynard was fine with me. He was picking up the hotels, which was a huge thing. And I was able to save quite a lot of money with Maynard. And I lived pretty thriftily on the road and I approached it as a tourist so I wouldn't go crazy. So I was taking pictures all over the place and when someone would rent a car for a couple of days we'd go out and see the sights and take the local car, which was nice.

MR: Was it easier at that time, regarding immigration and visas and all that, than it is now?

BJ: My whole immigration thing was very odd. I came in on an H2 visa, which means the arts, and I can stay for three months, then I had to go back, tag England, and then come

flight and come back. And then I decided that I wanted to do a green card route. And so I got a social security card and it was a matter of paying taxes, and so I got a lawyer in New York, an immigration lawyer. And I don't think this guy was particularly good, because it took me nearly three years from the time I engaged this lawyer until I actually got the call that it had been approved. And the laws were changing all the time, constantly, depending on which party was in power. For a while people were getting married to American citizens in order to hurry it along, and then the next administration said anybody who's married to an American citizen who's not a citizen has to go back to the home country and wait. And so a lot of people just were leaving. New Zealand being part of the Immigration Department's Asian quota, there were a lot of people from the end of the Viet Nam War who were coming in as refugees, and for me to go back to New Zealand and get on the back end of the line would have meant that it would have been over. So I asked this guy to pull whatever strings he could. And eventually I got a call. I was in Milwaukee with Woody Herman. And the lawyer called me at the hotel and he said, "um, you'd better get to New York in the morning, you've got an immigration hearing." Oh my God. So I got a red eye flight to New York and the guy met me and we zoomed over to the Immigration Department. Because I'd been approved already. I had that at least. I knew it was going to happen. But it was just the formality of going before a judge. So this guy was nervous, he's smoking cigarettes, and he says, "now listen, they're going to ask you all kinds of questions, have you ever consorted with prostitutes, have you ever been around anyone smoking marijuana — " I said, "oh come on." And he's pacing up and down. I'm calm as anything. So I assured him that everything was fine. I mean I had a wonderful reference letter from Clark Terry, who I'd played with. I mean it was just glowing. It was beautiful. It said this guy's going to be an asset for American music. So we went up and met in the judge's chambers. And the judge was a black lady, 50-ish. And she came out and she looked at my papers and she said, "oh you're playing with Woody Herman." And I said, "yes." And she said, "does he play 'Woodchopper's Ball'?" And I said, "oh yes, every night." And she said, "wow, I used to dance to him in college." It was stamped, here you go. And the lawyer said, "why didn't you tell me you had this kind of clout?" I said, "I've been telling you for three years." So then I was playing in Canada, because Woody was in Canada.

MR: Wow. That's cool.

BJ: So that was nice. It was good.

MR: What did you learn from those guys? Maynard or Woody. I mean, beyond the music.

BJ: I learned about working a crowd. Maynard didn't play on everything. He said you can only amaze people once. So that's why he surrounded himself with young players who

would come to see you, as well as Maynard. Because Maynard didn't really play hard on everything, it was just a few things. And he would space it just beautifully. And he just was a very personable guy. And the audiences really loved him. And it was great. He could whip up a crowd to a frenzy in a flash. It was wonderful. Woody was fiscally irresponsible unfortunately. He was taken advantage of by a lot of people, and in fact I think Artie Shaw bought his house so that Woody wouldn't have to lose it.

MR: Yeah, he was like deeply in debt to the government.

BJ: Horrible, horrible. But he would do things, he would drop us in a bus at some ratty hotel and then he'd go on to live at a much higher up the food chain type hotel. Either that or Buddy Rich. Buddy would not pay his guys for three or four weeks. So they were all indebted to him because they wanted the money that they'd already earned. And yet some of the greatest players in the world have come out of the "Buddy Rich School of Boot Camp." And they all loved him. They all loved him. And they all admired and respected him, even though he did stomp on them a little bit.

MR: Um hum. Did that include Don Menza?

BJ: Yes. Menza, Pat LaBarbara, Bobby Shew, I mean, tons of them — Ernie Watts, all those guys came out of that school.

MR: I guess if you can survive that then —

BJ: Everything's easy after that.

MR: It puts things in perspective.

BJ: Yeah. He offered it to me I think three times and I turned him down three times because I was doing other stuff. But a guy who used to follow me around all the time, his name was Jay Craig, a Scottish baritone player who had gone to Berklee, and he used to dog my footsteps, no matter where I was. Copped all my licks. Got on Buddy's band playing all my licks.

MR: Do you know that there's a little — now that you're at Fredonia — there's a little Fredonia story with Buddy. He came to play a concert, and this would have been probably '72. And his piano player was either ill or whatever, they had no piano player that night. And Onaje Allen Gumbs —

BJ: Oh yeah, I know Onaje.

MR: Well, he was still a student here. And he played the whole concert with him. And Buddy Rich offered him the gig right on the bandstand, in the big hall, in King Hall. And of course all of us are going, "take it, take it!" I mean because that was our dream.

BJ: That's right.

MR: And here's one of our own being asked. And he didn't take it. I think he was smart. He was too gentle a soul. He could not have handled any of that.

BJ: Yeah. The Buddy Rich survivors are pretty tough guys. Personality-wise, they're pretty bombastic.

MR: Well I have a couple of the different sides of what you do, and I just wanted to —
[audio interlude]
This is live, right?

BJ: Yup. Eight o'clock in the morning.

MR: This was eight o'clock in the morning?

BJ: Yup. Maynard had had some major tooth surgery, had part of his jaw taken out. His dentist was traveling with him to make sure that he didn't play. So for the first two weeks of his tour Maynard didn't play a note. We played in Boston the night before until about two in the morning, then we drove to New York. Nobody slept. And we went into this club, Jimmy's, at eight o'clock in the morning, and then did a sound check and then straight into it. And everything on that recording was live, one take. And when we opened up with "Blue Birdland" the deal was Maynard was going to overdub later. And we were playing the theme and all of a sudden Maynard grabbed his horn and went [scats] and the dentist's face went white. And Maynard played with no warm-up, strong as I've ever heard him. And the man was amazing.

MR: Talk about adrenaline.

BJ: Yeah.

MR: I think Thad Jones-Mel Lewis, they did a record like that with Joe Williams, where they were up all night and they just went into the studio.

BJ: Yeah. Sometimes you get that momentum building up to that moment — rather than he'd go in, have breakfast, and everything's calm and he said, "hello, good morning everybody," and they all have had coffee, and the spirit is not there.

MR: Yeah. You do a cool thing here.
[audio interlude]

BJ: Yeah. I learned it from —

MR: That's great. To get some tone to go with it, I think is hard.

BJ: The mouthpiece I was using on that was a Meyer ten, and I was using number five reeds. Of course in my declining years I've gone down one strength in reeds.

MR: Yes. It's not bad to go down. Wow.

BJ: Yeah. Some guy in New Zealand showed me how to slap tongue. His name was Max Stewart, and he was a baritone player from England, who'd come to New Zealand and started a jewelry store. And he had been a professional musician in England and he'd recorded all of Rudy Wiedoeft's material on baritone. So he did "Oodles of Noodles" and "Saxophobia," and all those old corny things. And he showed me how to do this slap

roof of your mouth, so, and you have the reed in there. So you're shutting the reed, and then the pressure behind it as you open the reed pops it. And you have just enough power to go through it to make the reed vibrate.

MR: Wow. Pretty cool. I'm going to try it. And then there's the, I think this is a nice contrast — I think this is you

[audio interlude]

I think you sent this to me. I could be mistaken.

BJ: Oh, no. That one's not me.

MR: Oh, okay.

BJ: Yeah. I'll send you a different one.

MR: Didn't you send me some string stuff?

BJ: Yeah. And this is something I started at the college, ever since I came to Fredonia. Well it was strange when I came to Fredonia because FJE [Fredonia Jazz Ensemble] was still there but they had — their musicality had dropped to the point where they would sit on stage and play "Chameleon" for twenty minutes.

MR: This was what year now?

BJ: 2001. And the rest of the people weren't soloing. They were sitting on the stand like this or they're bored.

MR: Did the administration know that was happening?

BJ: I think so. And I think I was hired to bring some structure to the FJE. However, the FJE thought that I was there to destroy them, and to get out of being their exclusive club and mainstream. And I wasn't there to do that at all. I started out with 14 kids who were brand new freshmen. We slammed a band together and played a concert three weeks after I started, in the library, which kind of shocked everybody, but it got everybody's attention. But it took me nearly four years before the FJE stopped hating me.

MR: You know that's — I'd heard that through — because I graduated in '72. FJE was a big part of our lives. And when I heard that at first I was astonished. And then I started to think about it and I said well when we were there we were all student run. They gave us a faculty advisor. And we always used to moan and bitch about —

BJ: The gorilla in the room?

MR: Yeah. But I think we had a lot of pride in the fact that we were doing this. So I can see how the students might think oh, now they're going to take it away from us.

BJ: And nobody asked me to. None of the FJE came to me and asked me. In fact they would pointedly — if I was walking down a hallway and somebody was coming the other way they would either turn or they would get as far away from me as possible. It was just rude. And so I put up with that for about four years, until most of these people who were

with me in the curricular bands, with sharing repertoires, the FJE would come to me and say do you have such and such a chart, can I borrow it. And I'd say sure, here you go. And they'll play it. And likewise, if they've got something great in their library that I'd like to borrow I just go ask them to borrow it, and then give it back to them. And so I think we're becoming more of colleagues than adversaries. So I'm very happy with the way it is. And so I'm one of the faculty advisors for the FJE and for the two big bands that they have. And it's good, because we interact. But I don't go and actually rehearse them. Because if I did that then their status as a student-run group would have been taken away and they'd lose all their funding. So I've been very supportive of them whenever I do a concert with the curricular band I'll always advertise the fact that — come and hear the FJE when they play. So I think we've broken down that barrier to the point where it's all very positive now.

MR: That's good. And your title is Curricular Jazz — do you teach people how to run a jazz band?

BJ: Yes.

MR: Well that's important. Because for years, I mean almost every high school or junior high has a jazz band now. But a lot of teachers have no idea, like —

BJ: I have teachers calling me, people who've graduated, and they'll call me and say, "um, I'm supposed to run this jazz ensemble and I've got nine alto players, what do I do?" And so I give them a little formula for doing that.

MR: What is the formula?

BJ: Don't double the lead alto player. Double the second. Put an alto player with the baritone. That's an octave apart. And you might have to transpose a tenor part, so you can do that. And then you get the full spread of sound. Even how to set up the saxophone section correctly. So it's first alto, second alto, first tenor, second tenor, baritone. Because that's the way the chord is voiced. And if you put two tenor players together then you get the kind of symphonic lag — how when you hear a stand partner to play —

MR: Oh. Say that again. That's interesting.

BJ: In symphony orchestras when you have two people on a stand invariably somebody is going to dominate. The other person could be a fraction behind. And often times they'll wait for the stand partner to make the move. And this way if you have the tenor players, they're not playing notes that clash up against each other, they're spread down the line, they're physically spread.

MR: That's interesting. Because we were discussing that this morning. "Well where do you want to sit? You want to put the tenors together?" And it's not because I knew this thing, but I said, "well let's not. Let's put — you know.

BJ: And you stack the lead players. Trumpet, trombone and alto, kind of in the middle of the stage. And then you have the baritone and bass trombone together because often times they're playing lines together. And the lead tenor player and second trumpet player are generally the soloists who'll come out to the mics so they're closest to the rhythm section.

MR: Have you ever set the band up —

BJ: Oh you mean like the Kenton "Flying V?"

MR: Yeah.

BJ: Yes I have. And in fact we've been rehearsing recently where the trumpets are facing this way, the trombones are facing this way, and the saxes facing the trumpets, just so that you can do it. I've also set them up where the trombones are in front, trumpets in the middle and the saxes in the back, which the Peter Herbolzheimer Band in Germany does that. So they have the saxes on a riser.

MR: Is it hard to teach piano players and guitarists especially, what to do in a big band?

BJ: Yes. It really is. A lot of them get so locked on with a part, and we have no jazz piano instructors at Fredonia. The piano studio cannot interpret chords. So I'm trying to do that, even though I'm not a piano player. Even with a gun to my head I'm not a piano player. But I can voice and I can use the keyboard as a writing thing. But as far as comping, piano players don't know how to comp. They think they have to play everything all the time. And I remember a clinic that Thad Jones did, somebody asked him, "what's the role of the piano player?" So he went over and sat at the piano stool, and count off the band, and he went [motions] sat on his hands. The pianist is there mostly as a soloist or to keep things on track if there's a lull in what the brass and saxes are doing, just to kind of keep the chords straight. My whole thing is that the bass player is the timekeeper, because they play four to the bar. The drummer is the time enhancer. And their job is to signal when the kicks are coming from the brass, or just to kind of get underneath the soloist and help. And that's been pretty good. A lot of the soloists don't realize how important the rhythm of soloing is. And I'm trying to get them to work off the ride cymbal like the pattern [scats]. If you're playing, and the kids are all about [scats], then they're right here, half note, triplets, which drag over a bar, and this kid is lost completely. But I tried something last Monday. It's like watching a person drowning. They'll either go under or they'll go [scats] which means they don't have a clue. I tried something which I thought was kind of rad, but I had a lot of kids soloing for the very first time. And I asked each of them to say their name to me. Because every person's name has a rhythm to it. And a little trumpet player, her name was Jody White, which is three syllables. So I added two notes, that's it. Okay. Your phrase is going to be "here comes Jody White." Five notes. So I said

that rhythm. She walked through "Day by Day," fine. Just absolutely fine. And I said, "all you have to do, when this chord comes up, you have to move it from a C down a step to a B flat, and it will sound just fine." And it was great. Light bulbs were going on in people's heads. And it was something like I'd used before but pretty much for myself. I mean if I'm playing someplace and I'm getting bored, I can look at somebody and think the word phrase of "that's the ugliest dress I've ever seen," or "bad day at the beauty salon." And you can do that and people don't realize it but it becomes personal because you're playing phrases that work with the rhythm section. Because it's not about the soloist. The soloist is the glue that holds everything together. Because the bass player is playing four and shaping where the chords go. The pianist is comping, almost like that backward Charleston rhythm [scats], so that's incomplete. The drummer is dropping bombs and little things. It's an incomplete thing until the soloist comes on and plays. And I'll say to the soloist we expect the rhythm section — the pianist and the bass player — to be playing the correct notes, the correct chords. They expect you to be playing the correct notes too. I said you can't just blindly go off on a tangent and expect the rhythm section to respect you.

MR: So there's wrong notes in jazz?

BJ: Oh yeah.

MR: Well —

BJ: Although they're only a half step away from the right one at any time.

MR: That's become — I have to admit, I've been asking that question a lot. And some people immediately say — if I phrase it, "are there wrong notes in improvising?" They'll say, "no." Most of them will then qualify that statement. But I'm pretty much with you. I think yes there's wrong notes but there's ways to deal with them. But a lot of the younger players are going at it from the other way —

BJ: There are degrees of wrongness too.

MR: There's no wrong notes as long as you resolve them, as long you play them with attitude, as long as you know you're playing an incorrect tone.

BJ: And you know the scales.

MR: I'm going to assume that, well fill in the blank — if you were to say, "I am X percent self-taught," for yourself.

BJ: 80.

MR: 80 percent.

BJ: Mostly because there was no music education in the schools in New Zealand when I was growing up. And my clarinet teacher at the time had said, I had asked him about chords. And he said, "well jazz musicians just play by ear." So I said, "okey dokey, I'm going to

MR: So now that you're in academia, how much do you embrace jazz improv methods and terms and modes and enclosures and all that?

BJ: I try to put on a very practical, hands-on method. Harry Jacobson is focusing on that. And my thing is to take what he's given them and put in here and then put it on the instrument. So it's practical, and they become employable.

MR: Wow. What a great statement. I mean it seems so obvious to me, but I don't think it always is, especially in this day and age. I mean there's so much — where are all these musicians going to go to find work?

BJ: That's right. Because the big music schools are cranking out people like crazy. And the people in New York who are employers, in clubs, realize that they can get people cheaper and cheaper and cheaper to play music in their clubs, until you've got people playing for nothing.

MR: Or paying to play.

BJ: Absolutely. And I won't do that. And one of the reasons I started a string group was I want the string players — for that small percentage who do get picked up by major orchestras and are earning a paycheck with a major orchestra — to be able to interpret the oddities of jazz phrasing, and to have another paycheck from the other side of the street, and so I'm teaching people how to phrase running eighth notes with the underlying 12/8 feel, and the oddities of chordal placement, and the chord voicings, so that the clashes don't become foreign or frightening to them. Because a lot of things people are doing for strings, and I work a lot with the Buffalo Philharmonic, major acts will come in and the string parts are dumbed down so hard, whereas they can do some beautiful stuff, things that John Williams has written, or Alan Broadbent has written, things which have a bit of a technical challenge, which creates interest within the string section. And once you have a bunch of people interested in backing up the front person you really get that support. And I started the strings kind of as a selfish move. Because I've always loved playing with strings. And nobody was doing it. Nobody was playing jazz with strings. And the only things that I found out the publishers have is in a Beatles medley for beginners strings, and this is stuff that their grandparents listened to. They're not familiar with The Beatles, at all. They listen to a whole other bunch of things. So I'm trying to bring some different things so that we do some good standards, we do some ballads, we do some Brazilian things, and some kind of soft rock/pop things.

MR: And how many do you have?

BJ: Ten. Ten strings. And I use first, second, third violins, like Charlie Parker's stuff. And nowadays it's usually first and second and then violas. But I have two firsts, two seconds, two thirds, two violas, two cellos. And then piano, bass, drums, guitar — and I'll send

for this kid. Because you don't hear viola solos too often. And he was thrilled to come up front. He played it, and the applause was deafening and he had this big smile on his face. They relax on stage when they're playing this stuff with me. I kind of take a glance on the cello — they're grooving — and it's really delightful.

MR: And you're writing with a pencil and paper.

BJ: Yes. And I'm having to do it all because there's nothing out there that's been published. There's a great writer by the name of Calvin Custer who is the Syracuse Symphony's musical director. I have a couple of his things. And when I first started writing, that was the model that was taken. Him, Alan Broadbent, Claus Ogerman. And he was using three violins as well. And the sound that he got, and the strength that he got, it was just a huge, big, warm layer of sound, which was just so nice.

MR: Are you upbeat or downbeat — no puns intended — about where jazz lives in our culture now?

BJ: I'm a little bit down on it I think. I think there's a lot of ego out there — that jazz musicians are making recordings, and they're very difficult to sit down and enjoy. They're so intellectually ahead of the audiences. A lot of audiences go — later for this, and they're walking away. In fact, I saw this happen. I was playing at a jazz festival in Boise, Idaho. Michael Brecker was the headliner. Michael was brilliant. He had Joey Calderazzo on piano, Reginald Veal on bass, and Jeff Watts on drums. And he was playing all this stuff from "Tales From the Hudson," which had yet to come out. And from the end of his first tune, and for the rest of his concert, there was a constant stream of people walking out, because he was playing intellectually so far above what people had been listening to, that it was difficult for them to follow. And I've always been a slowed down, working with sound rather than technique kind of person. You can say more with your sound. You don't have to play a thousand notes. You don't get paid by the note. But if you play the sound and reach the audience and tell the story, because a story — I play saxophone because I'm a lousy singer.

MR: I think that's a really interesting statement. Because it says you are trying to get your message out like a singer. Singers have the benefit and the burden of the words sometimes.

BJ: Yes. And their job is to relate that to the audience so that they can feel if there's anger or if there's pathos, whatever emotion that we're trying to throw at them from the stage — joy or sorrow — that the audience can feel this at the same time. And I have this kid who's a great tenor player, who's at Fredonia. He's a freshman — no he's a sophomore now. He came as a freshman. The kid plays like Bob Mintzer. He just rips over it. Extensions, everything. But I'm trying to get his softer side in. So I found in the FJE

have saxophone players who can double, which is fantastic. So I ran this out for him. He played such an aggressive solo, it was — I'd say this would be like on a date with your girlfriend in a car and you grab her by the shirt and you say, "I love you dammit." I said, "she'd be out of the car in a heartbeat if you were doing that." I said, "you've got to put some tenderness into it and realize what the lyrics are." So I told him, "learn the lyrics. Play the lyrics, and tell the story that way." And I also tell the vocalist the same thing. Phrase it as if you're speaking. It's something I do with vocalists is before they sing it I'll have them stand there and talk it to me. Just tell the story in my ear. And then when I believe that they are believing the story, then we get the microphones and start singing it. And then they have an understanding of what's going on.

MR: Wow. It sounds like you're doing really good stuff. Our tape's going to run out pretty soon. But I wanted to go back. You said the magic word to me early on. I'm a huge Cannonball fan, and always have been. And I wonder, why are you?

BJ: It was, I got the feeling of absolute joy when he played. It was life, it was joy, it was come on, let's do it. And that's what I tried to bring, rather than just slugging over patterns and things, I wanted to bring some kind of joy to what's played. And I actually got to meet him before he passed away. We were playing at McCoy Place in Chicago. And I did the ugly fan thing. Said "oh, I've copped all your licks and I've listened to all your albums." And he said, "oh, that's great." He said, "well I've heard you too." Because he had the "Live at Jimmy's" album. And so he said, "do you get a solo?" And I said, "yeah, at the end of the set." And he said, "I'll be there." And so I got up to play, got the sprit thing, and all of a sudden in my peripheral vision I noticed Cannonball sliding into the wings. And he stayed there until the end, so he heard the whole thing. And when we were done he wasn't there anymore. And I ran into him again, he was coming up the hallway, walking with a bunch of reporters. And he just kept on talking but he reached out and gave me the thumbs up.

MR: Nice.

BJ: I was unapproachable for a week. And I was very sad when he died.

MR: Really. Me too. And Nat, and the whole thing, it was just perfect, the way he took soul jazz and infused it with his personality, and the way he talked to the crowd.

BJ: Yeah, he was very folksy but a great guy. A former school teacher.

MR: Yup. And that sound you know. I kid my students, I say, "I'm now going to play for you're the greatest note ever played." And I play the build-up in "Mercy Mercy" when it goes [scats].

BJ: Yup.

MR: And he plays that note and, I don't know, maybe it's just me but —

BJ: Well I have the exact model mouthpiece that he had, a New York Meyer hard rubber 5, which I use on alto. I use the same strength reeds that he used. And I have a King Super 20 alto.

MR: Do you know when he switched horns I noticed it on his records. He started playing Selmers at some point.

BJ: A different sound.

MR: Yeah. Maybe he was getting free instruments or something.

BJ: Could be. He changed mouthpieces a couple of times too.

MR: Well this has been a real pleasure.

BJ: Well thank you.

MR: And I knew it was going to be. I just had a feeling that this was going to be great. Did you ever take a globe and draw your path? You know, because I think you should, because I think it's really interesting. You know, Australia, England, France — and now you're here at Fredonia.

BJ: Well the one that I saw was Flip Phillips had a tenor and he had engravings on the bell and the bowl of a bus and a little plane and a railroad train, and he had dates on all of these things, and his whole life on the horn. But I'm having a wonderful time, and I couldn't think of a better way to have done it.

MR: Great. Well on that positive note, I want to thank you very much.

BJ: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Over and out.